

JORVIK & Viking York - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Jorvik: The Viking Capital of England

The Great Heathen Army took York on the first of November, 866 — a date likely chosen because the Northumbrian elite was in church — and what followed matters more than the raid: nearly a century of Scandinavian rule in which Jorvik became one of the great trading cities of the North Atlantic world, second in Britain only to London, with a population estimated over ten thousand. The Coppergate finds document its reach: silk probably from Byzantium or beyond, a counterfeit dirham of Samarkand, Baltic amber, a Red Sea cowrie shell, Norwegian honestones and Rhineland lava querns — globalization, tenth-century edition. The Viking kings of York end with the era's best-named figure, Eric Bloodaxe, ex-king of Norway, expelled and killed in 954, after which the city fell to the English crown — but the Scandinavian imprint proved permanent: York's street names (the “-gate” suffix is Old Norse *gata*, street), a dialect substrate across the North, and the very name York, worn down from Jorvik. The deeper point the JORVIK Centre makes is a corrective: the horned-helmet raider of legend was, in York, a craftsman, merchant or farmer within a generation — cup-turners on Coppergate, moneyers striking coins for Viking kings who adopted Christianity with commercial pragmatism, sometimes stamping St Peter's name on one side of a coin and Thor's hammer on the other. Hedged bets, in silver.

Related listening: The museum's buried ship and walrus-ivory chessmen set the stage for Viking York. Listen back — “Sutton Hoo and the Lewis Chessmen: Two Buried Worlds” (British Museum, Day 5).

The Horned Helmet That Never Was

The JORVIK galleries make a point of it, and it is worth dwelling on, because it is one of the most successful pieces of misinformation in popular history. Vikings did not wear horned helmets. There is no archaeological evidence for them, none, and there are good practical reasons why not. A horn or a wing on a helmet is a lever, an obliging handle for an enemy to grab, and a snag for every passing branch and blade. Warriors who fought for a living wore what worked, a plain domed iron cap, and the honest truth is that most Vikings, most of the time, probably wore no helmet at all, since iron was costly and a good helmet was a rich man's kit.

How thin is the evidence? Consider that in the entire Viking age, across all of Scandinavia and the lands the Vikings reached, archaeologists have recovered essentially one helmet complete enough to reconstruct, the Gjermundbu helmet, pieced together from fragments found on a Norwegian farm in nineteen forty-three. It is a rounded iron cap with a fearsome spectacle-like guard over the eyes and nose. No horns. That is very nearly the entire canon of near-complete Viking helmets. One.

So where did the horns come from? The theatre, and specifically the eighteen seventies. When Richard Wagner staged his epic four-opera Ring cycle at Bayreuth in eighteen seventy-six, his costume designer, a painter named Carl Emil Doepler, dressed the gods and heroes in horned and winged helmets to conjure a primitive, mythic, thunderously Germanic past. The look was a sensation. It spread from the opera house into paintings, book illustrations, advertising and, eventually, every cartoon and cereal box, until the

horned Viking became one of the most instantly recognisable images on earth, and completely fictional. It is a rare case of being able to name almost exactly when and where a myth was born.

There is a teasing grain of truth underneath. Genuinely horned helmets do exist from Scandinavia, but from the Bronze Age, more than a thousand years before the first Viking, and they were ceremonial religious objects, never war gear, the sort of thing worn by a priest in a ritual, of which only a couple survive. The Vikings themselves would have found them as ancient and strange as we find the Vikings.

Keep it in mind at the helmet displays here, and later before the genuine article across town in the Yorkshire Museum. Real Viking-age armour is plainer, cleverer and far more interesting than the pantomime version, which is rather the whole thesis of this museum.

Egil, Bloodaxe, and the Poem That Bought a Head

The base story leaves Eric Bloodaxe expelled and dead in nine fifty-four, the last Viking king of York, but he has a second life in literature that is worth carrying with you. Eric strides through the Icelandic sagas, written down two or three centuries later, and the greatest of them, Egil's Saga, sets one of its most famous scenes in Viking York itself.

The saga tells it like this. Egil Skallagrimsson, a towering, ugly, volcanically bad-tempered Icelandic warrior-poet, is shipwrecked on the coast of Northumbria and finds himself, of all the terrible luck, in the city ruled by Eric Bloodaxe, a man with every reason to want him dead. Egil had been feuding with Eric and his formidable queen, Gunnhild, for years, and had killed one of the king's sons. Gunnhild, in the saga a schemer and a sorceress, presses her husband to execute him on the spot.

Egil's friend Arinbjorn offers desperate advice. Compose a poem, he says, a great praise-poem for the king, overnight, and deliver it in the morning. So, the saga claims, Egil stayed up the whole night in Jorvik and produced a dazzling praise-poem of some twenty stanzas in Eric's honour, later known as the Hofudlausn, which means the head-ransom. He stood before the king and his warriors and performed it. And Eric, though he loathed the man, could not put to death someone who had just publicly glorified him without staining his own honour before his whole court. He let Egil walk out of York with his head still on his shoulders.

How much of this is true? The events are wrapped in legend, and scholars argue about whether the surviving poem is really Egil's and how much history sits behind the tale. But the scene captures something absolutely real about this world, the astonishing status of the skald, the court poet. In a society without newspapers, a poet could make or destroy a king's reputation, and reputation was the very currency of power. Verse was not decoration. It was propaganda, memory, insult and, on at least one legendary night in this city, a literal ransom for a man's life.

So Jorvik is not only a place of combs and cups and coprolites. It is a stage in the sagas, a city grand and dangerous enough that the greatest poet of the age gambled his life on a single night's work here. When you stand on Coppergate, you stand where the Norse imagination set one of its finest stories, the night a clever man out-talked an axe.

Coppergate: The Dig That Changed Urban Archaeology

The 1976 to 81 Coppergate excavation, directed by the York Archaeological Trust ahead of a shopping-center development, is one of the landmark digs of the twentieth century, and its significance was chemical before it was historical: the site's waterlogged, anoxic clays preserved organic material — structural timber, wattle, leather, textile, seeds, insects, parasite eggs — on a scale almost never seen in Britain. The team recovered around forty thousand objects and, more importantly, entire tenement plots: post-and-wattle then plank-built structures with walls surviving waist-high, property boundaries that remained stable for a millennium (the modern street preserves the Viking-age plot lines), and workshop floors identifying Coppergate's industries — wood-turning (the street name means street of the cup-makers), metalworking including coin dies, amber and antler working. The environmental archaeology was revolutionary: beetle and parasite assemblages reconstructed diet, hygiene and living conditions with unprecedented granularity — hence the celebrated Lloyds Bank coprolite, whose whipworm and maw-worm eggs quantify the era's intestinal reality. Public engagement was equally novel: the dig ran viewing platforms and drew enormous crowds, and when it closed, the Trust built JORVIK in the excavation's footprint in 1984, pioneering the ride-through reconstruction — smells included — that every subsequent "experience" museum has copied. Purists sniffed; five decades and millions of visitors later, the model looks like foresight. The glass floor over conserved deposits, and figures whose faces are forensic reconstructions from excavated skulls, keep the spectacle honestly tethered to evidence.

The Coppergate Helmet

Amid the forty thousand finds, one object stands slightly apart, because it predates the Vikings and because it is, quite simply, one of the finest early medieval helmets ever discovered. The Coppergate helmet, also called the York helmet, surfaced on the twelfth of May, nineteen eighty-two, in the least dignified way imaginable. The controlled excavation had moved on, a mechanical digger was clearing ground for the new development, and its bucket struck something solid at the bottom of a pit that had probably once been a well. The operator stopped. What emerged from the mud, once cleaned and conserved, was an eighth-century Anglo-Saxon helmet, made roughly a century before the Great Army ever reached York.

It is a superb piece of engineering and display. An iron cap with a nose guard and hinged iron cheek-pieces, it carries a curtain of mail to protect the neck, decorative brass eyebrows terminating in a small animal head, and, running from brow to nape and ear to ear, brass crest strips bearing a Latin inscription. That inscription is the extraordinary part. It is a Christian invocation, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit and God, and it ends by naming a man, Oshere. We do not know who Oshere was, but the name almost certainly identifies the helmet's owner, an Anglo-Saxon of high rank in eighth-century Northumbria, when York was a Christian centre of learning famous across Europe.

The rarity is hard to overstate. From the whole of Anglo-Saxon England, spanning some six hundred years, only a tiny number of helmets survive, and you can more or less list them, Sutton Hoo, Benty Grange, the Pioneer helmet from Wollaston, Shorwell, and this one from Coppergate, which is among the best preserved of them all. Each is a once-in-a-generation find. That York should yield one, by fluke, from the bucket of a digger, is the kind of luck archaeology occasionally throws up to remind everyone how much still lies unread beneath modern streets.

Why it was in the pit remains genuinely unresolved. It may have been deliberately concealed for safekeeping in troubled times and never retrieved, or deposited as some kind of offering. Whatever the reason, the same waterlogged, oxygen-starved ground that preserved the Viking city's leather and timber also cradled

this helmet for twelve centuries. It is not shown here, but a short walk away in the Yorkshire Museum, and it rewards the detour. Few objects connect you so directly, and by name, to a single individual standing in this place well over a thousand years ago.

The Workshops of Coppergate

The base story credits Coppergate with wood-turning, metalwork and amber. Stand for a moment on what the excavation actually revealed, tenement by tenement, because it amounts to a portrait of a working industrial street, and it is more sophisticated than the word Viking usually conjures.

The name declares the flagship trade. Coppergate is Old Norse for the street of the cup-makers, the koppari, and the ground was thick with the evidence, thousands of discarded lathe-cores, the waste plugs left when a bowl or cup is turned on a pole lathe. These were not amateurs whittling by the fire. This was serial production of turned wooden vessels, an entire block given over to it. Alongside worked the comb-makers, a specialised and often travelling craft, sawing and riveting red-deer antler into fine double-sided combs, since antler flexes where wood splits, and personal grooming was a genuine Viking preoccupation, remarked upon, with some disapproval, by English chroniclers.

Then the finer materials. Amber, fossil tree resin traded down from the Baltic, was worked here into beads and pendants, as was jet, the black fossil wood from the coast at Whitby, long prized for ornament and reputed to ward off harm. Non-ferrous metalworkers cast and finished brooches, strap-ends and pins in copper alloy, silver and lead, and, crucially, coin dies were found, placing the royal moneyers' operation in or near this street, striking the silver that powered the city. Ironsmiths, leatherworkers producing shoes and sheaths and belts, and bone-workers turning waste into skates, pins and gaming pieces round out the picture.

The subtlest evidence is textile. Jorvik's households spun and wove wool, and environmental sampling recovered the plants used to dye it, madder for reds and species yielding yellows, with evidence for woad blues, meaning the reconstructed grey-brown Viking of popular imagination is wrong twice over, once for the horns and once for the colours. These were people who liked, and could afford, bright cloth.

What makes all this remarkable is not any single luxury but the concentration and the continuity. The property boundaries laid out around the year nine hundred stayed fixed for generations, each narrow plot a house-and-workshop passing down a trade, fronting a street of shops. This is recognisably urban economic life, specialised, commercial and regulated, several centuries before the medieval guilds we usually credit with inventing it. The genius of Coppergate is that the mud preserved not the treasures of the elite but the machinery of an ordinary economy, the offcuts and failures and half-finished pieces that show us not what Jorvik owned, but what Jorvik did all day.

The Viking Dig, and the Flood That Nearly Ended It

The base story credits the Coppergate excavation with changing archaeology. It is worth putting a name to the man who ran it, because he made a choice that was, for its day, quietly radical. Richard Hall, an archaeologist who had joined the York Archaeological Trust in nineteen seventy-four, took charge of the Coppergate site in nineteen seventy-six, and as the waterlogged Viking city began to rise out of the ground, he did something most excavation directors of the era would never have contemplated. He let the public in to watch.

Rather than screen the trench behind hoardings, as was normal, Hall built viewing platforms and opened the working dig to anyone who cared to look. His argument was simple, and faintly heretical: York's Viking past did not belong to scholars, it belonged to the people of York, and they had a right to see it come out of the mud with their own eyes. The response was staggering. Over the five years of digging, the site drew more than a million visitors, queuing down the street to peer down into a live archaeological

trench while trowels scraped and finds trays filled. The newspapers christened it the Viking Dig, and it became a genuine national event, archaeology as public theatre, a thing almost unheard of before and routine ever since. When people talk about JORVIK inventing the visitor-facing museum, this is really where it started, in the trench, not the ride. The Centre that opened in nineteen eighty-four was simply Hall's viewing platform made permanent.

Which lends a certain drama to the winter of twenty fifteen. On Boxing Day, after days of ferocious rain across the Dales, the River Foss overwhelmed its defences and floodwater surged into the low-lying streets around Coppergate, pouring straight down into JORVIK. By the morning of the twenty-eighth, the reconstructed Viking street lay under roughly a metre of dirty water. Staff and volunteers scrambled to rescue the collection, carrying artefacts up out of the drowned galleries by hand. The Centre closed, and stayed closed for sixteen months.

There is a bitter symmetry in it that the archaeologists appreciated more than anyone. The very thing that had preserved the real Jorvik for a thousand years, water, sealing the ground airless and wet so nothing could rot, was the thing that now nearly destroyed the copy. But the story ends well. After a restoration costing some four and a third million pounds, with proper flood defences built in this time, JORVIK reopened in April of twenty seventeen, comprehensively rebuilt, with new reconstructions and new galleries reflecting everything researchers had learned in the decades since the dig. So the version you are about to ride through is, in a real sense, the third Jorvik. The first was Viking. The second came out of Richard Hall's trench. The third rose, defiantly, out of the flood.

What the Vikings Left Behind — and a Trip Coda

JORVIK makes a fitting final stop because it inverts the trip's usual lens. The Tower, the palaces, the Minster — those are history as the powerful built it. Coppergate is history as everyone else left it: worn-out shoes resoled twice, a child's whetstone, bone ice skates for the frozen Ouse, lice combs (the Vikings were, by the standards of the age, notably well-groomed — English chroniclers grumbled that Danes bathed weekly and combed their hair, and won over local women accordingly), gaming pieces, and door-key after door-key, each implying a lock, a house, a household. The DNA legacy is measurable: studies of Yorkshire surnames and Y-chromosomes show substantial Norse ancestry across the old Danelaw, and everyday English still runs on the contact between Old English and Old Norse — egg, knife, window, husband, law, they — words so basic we forget they were imports. If the group has appetite left after the ride, the associated DIG attraction lets kids excavate replica trenches, and Viking-age York's other great artifact is free: walk Coppergate, Ousegate and Stonegate and you're following the tenth-century street plan itself. Then it's the 17:11 south — down the same corridor the Great Heathen Army marched up, at rather better speed — with two days of Viking mud, minster glass and city walls to argue about over dinner. As trip finales go, ending with the world's most famous coprolite has a certain honesty.

The Body of Evidence: Food, Dress, and Health

The environmental science at Coppergate did something monuments never can. It reconstructed the ordinary Viking body, what it ate, what it wore, and what ailed it, in forensic detail. As a coda to a fortnight of kings and cathedrals, it is worth ending at this human scale.

Diet first. Jorvik ate a coarse dark bread ground on rotary querns of imported Rhineland lava, and the stone shed grit into the flour, which is why Viking-age teeth are so distinctively worn flat, ground down over a lifetime of abrasive loaves. Around that staple came beef, pork and mutton, poultry and eggs, dairy turned to cheese and butter, and a steadily rising reliance on fish. From gardens and hedgerows came cabbages, leeks, onions, peas, beans, apples, sloes, plums and hazelnuts, sweetened only by honey. It was a calorie-dense, salty, seasonal diet, and by the standards of the age, in a prosperous trading town, a reasonably good one.

Dress next, and here the popular image fails twice. Not only were there no horns, there was no drab palette. Textile and dye-plant evidence shows wool coloured with madder reds, plant yellows and woad blues. Even the calendar remembers their habits, the Old Norse word for Saturday, still used across Scandinavia, means washing-day, the bath-day, a small linguistic fossil of a culture clean and colourful enough to keep both the comb-makers and the bath-house in business. The grey, matted Viking of the films is wrong about grime and hue alike.

And health, which is where honesty is owed. Life was short and hard. Skeletal populations from Viking York show heavy tooth wear and abscesses, joint disease and healed fractures from lives of physical labour, and the intestinal parasites made famous by the coprolite were effectively universal in a city with no sanitation, where people, animals and waste shared close, damp quarters. Childhood was dangerous, and many did not reach adulthood. The bones do not romanticise.

Put together, the picture is neither the horned barbarian nor the noble savage, but something more valuable, recognisable people, decently fed for their day, fond of colour and cleanliness, riddled with worms, worn down by grit and toil, trading with half the known world and dying young. That is the quiet achievement of this place. It reconstructs, from seeds and bones and parasite eggs, not an idea of the Vikings but the lived texture of individual lives, which is a far rarer thing for a museum to offer, and a fitting last image to carry south with you.

Silver, Coins, and the Making of a Market

One more layer for the road, and it is the layer that actually built Jorvik. Money. Behind the combs and the coprolite lay a sophisticated silver economy, and York was one of its great engines, home to a royal mint whose coin-dies turned up in the Coppergate dig itself.

The Viking kings of York grasped very quickly that coinage was both cash and propaganda. Their moneyers struck fine silver pennies, and the messages stamped on them are a masterclass in political hedging. Some coins of Viking York carry the name of Saint Peter, the city's patron, in Christian lettering, yet pair it with a sword, or with the hammer of Thor, pagan and Christian insurance on a single coin. Others carried a raven, the bird of Odin and of the battlefield. These were rulers converting to Christianity for hard commercial and diplomatic reasons while keeping the old gods in reserve, and they announced exactly that, in silver, in everyone's purse.

The wider economy ran on that silver by weight as much as by face value. Traders carried folding balances and sets of weights, many of which survive, and where a whole coin was too much they simply cut it, which is why hoards across the Viking world are full of hacksilver, chopped fragments of coin and ornament valued on the scales. A Samarkand dirham, a Frankish penny and a snapped-off brooch corner could all settle the same debt if the weights agreed. This is a monetary culture both primitive and startlingly cosmopolitan, indifferent to whose face was on the metal so long as the metal was good.

And it was governed. A working mint implies royal authority, agreed standards and enforcement, the machinery of a state guaranteeing and taxing its market. Combined with those stable property boundaries on Coppergate, the fixed street plan and the specialised workshops, the coins complete a picture that ought to retire any lingering sense of the Vikings as mere raiders. Tenth-century Jorvik was a governed commercial city with a money supply, an international reach and an administration, second in Britain only to London.

So as your train pulls south, carry this last correction. The men who took York in eight sixty-six with the Great Army are remembered for the axe, but what they actually built here was a market, minted and weighed and taxed, plugged into a trade network that ran from Dublin to Samarkand. The horns were never real. The silver, weighed to the last cut fragment, absolutely was.

1066: The Viking Age Ends Just Up the Road

Here is a fact that reframes the whole day. The Viking age did not fade quietly away. It ended, quite precisely, seven miles east of where you are standing, on the twenty-fifth of September, ten sixty-six. At a river crossing called Stamford Bridge, an English king destroyed the last great Viking army ever to invade Britain, and the man who died there, Harald Hardrada, King of Norway, is often called the last true Viking. Three centuries of Scandinavian raiding, trading and ruling closed on a single hot afternoon in the Yorkshire fields outside this city. It is one of the most consequential battles in English history, and almost nobody has heard of it, because of what happened nineteen days later at a place called Hastings. The two are the same story. The English army that beat the Vikings here marched two hundred and fifty miles south, exhausted, to meet William of Normandy, and lost, and everything about England changed. So York does not just hold the beginning of the Viking age in England, the trading city in the mud beneath you. It holds the end of it too, in a field down the road. The whole arc, raiders to rulers to defeated invaders, begins and ends within a day's ride of here.

Related listening: Holy Island, seen from the train, is where the Viking Age began in 793. Listen back — “Berwick, the Border, and Arriving in Edinburgh” (Train to Edinburgh, Day 8). Related listening: 1066 joins them: the Viking Age ended near York the same year the Conqueror's Tower story began. Listen back — “The White Tower: Architecture as Intimidation” (Tower of London, Day 3).

Where It All Began: Lindisfarne, 793

If Stamford Bridge is the end of the age, it is worth pausing on the beginning, partly because you have already met it on this trip. On the train up the east coast on the eighth day, you passed within sight of a low tidal island off the Northumberland shore, Lindisfarne, Holy Island, and heard how the Viking age is conventionally said to have begun there. Hold the two places together in your mind today, the island and the field outside York, because they are the bookends of everything.

On the eighth of June, seven ninety-three, Norse ships came ashore at Lindisfarne, then the most sacred site in the kingdom of Northumbria, a monastery famous across Christendom for its learning and its gorgeous illuminated gospels. The raiders killed monks, drowned some in the sea, carried others off as slaves, and stripped the church of its treasures. To modern eyes it is one raid among many. To the people of the time it was an earthquake. The scholar Alcuin of York, an Englishman then working at the court of Charlemagne, wrote a letter of pure horror, saying that never before had such a terror appeared in Britain, that the church of Saint Cuthbert was spattered with the blood of the priests of God. The shock was not just the violence. It was that the violence had struck the holiest, safest, most God-protected place imaginable, and God had not stopped it. Something new and frightening had arrived from across the sea.

From that raid you can draw a straight line to the ground under your feet. The lightning raids of the seven nineties gave way, within two generations, to something far more ambitious. The raiders stopped leaving. In eight sixty-six a great army came not to loot but to conquer and settle, and it made York its capital, and Jorvik was born. The pirates of Lindisfarne became the merchants of Coppergate. And then, in ten sixty-six, a Norwegian king sailed up the Ouse to claim the whole thing as his birthright, and met an English army that ended it all.

So the span is neat and almost poetic. Seven ninety-three to ten sixty-six, from the blood on the sand at Lindisfarne to the blood in the grass at Stamford Bridge, a little under three centuries. You have now stood, on a single fortnight's holiday, at both ends of the Viking age in England, the terror that opened it and the field that closed it. The mud of this city is the long, prosperous, surprisingly civilised middle.

Three Battles in Three Weeks, and the Road to the Tower

The autumn of ten sixty-six is the most dramatic month in English history, and York sits at the heart of it. Let me walk you through it, because the pace is almost unbelievable.

When old King Edward the Confessor died at the start of the year childless, three men claimed his throne. Harold Godwinson, the most powerful English earl, was crowned at once. But William, Duke of Normandy, insisted the crown had been promised to him, and began building a fleet. And Harald Hardrada of Norway, a giant of a man who had served in the imperial guard in Constantinople and fought his way across half the known world, decided he had a claim too, and threw in with Harold's own embittered brother, Tostig. So all summer, King Harold of England waited on the south coast, watching for William's sails, while the real blow came from the north.

In September, Hardrada's fleet, some three hundred ships, sailed up the Ouse. On the twentieth, just outside York at a place called Fulford, the Norwegians crushed the local northern earls in a hard, bloody fight, and York opened its gates to them. And then King Harold did something extraordinary. Hearing the news in the south, he gathered his household troops and force-marched them north, covering something like two hundred miles in only a few days, and fell on the Norwegian army so unexpectedly that many of them, caught relaxing in the late-September heat, had left their heavy mail armour back at the ships.

That was Stamford Bridge, the twenty-fifth of September. It gave us one of the great images of the age, preserved in the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle. As the English swarmed forward, a single Norse warrior, a huge man with an axe, planted himself in the middle of the narrow wooden bridge and held the entire English army at bay, cutting down, so the chronicle claims, some forty men, buying his comrades time to form a shield-wall on the far bank. He was undone only when an Englishman floated downriver beneath the bridge in a barrel or a boat and drove a spear up through the planks into him. Whatever the exact truth of it, the battle was a catastrophe for the Norwegians. Hardrada took an arrow in the throat. Tostig died too. Of the three hundred ships that had come, the survivors needed only about twenty-four to carry them home. The last great Viking invasion of England was simply annihilated.

And here is the cruelty of history. Harold barely had time to bury his dead before word came that William had landed in the south. He turned his exhausted, blood-soaked, thinned-out army around and marched them the whole length of England again, and on the fourteenth of October met the Normans at Hastings, and there, late in the day, an arrow, or a Norman blade, finished him, and England fell to the Duke of Normandy.

Now carry this back to where your whole trip began, on the very first days, at the Tower of London. William built that Tower, the great White Tower at its heart, to hold down a conquered city and cow a conquered people. And here is the thread that closes the circle. The Normans were themselves Vikings. Barely a century and a half earlier, a Norse warlord named Rollo had been granted a stretch of the French coast, which took his people's name and became Normandy, the land of the Northmen. William was Rollo's direct descendant. So the Viking age in England does not really end with a defeat at all. It ends with one branch of the Vikings, the Norse of Scandinavia, being wiped out in a field outside York, and another branch, the Norse gone French, the Normans, winning the whole country three weeks later and building the fortress where you started this holiday. You have travelled, this fortnight, from the Tower the Vikings' cousins built to the city the Vikings themselves made. It was their story the entire time.

The Sons of Ragnar and the Danelaw

The base story opens with the Great Heathen Army taking York in eight sixty-six, and moves quickly on to the city they built. But it is worth knowing who led that army, and what its conquest actually created, because the answer is half a country. According to the Norse sagas, the army was commanded by the sons of a legendary Viking chieftain named Ragnar Lothbrok, chief among them a figure with the wonderful, chilling epithet Ivar the Boneless. The sagas say they came to York specifically to avenge their father, supposedly put to a horrible death by the Northumbrian king. How much of that is history and how much is a good story told centuries later, we will come to. What is not in doubt is the result. Within a few years the Great Army had shattered the old English kingdoms of the north and east, and carved out a vast territory where Danish kings ruled and Danish law held sway. It even had a name, the Danelaw, and it covered most of England north and east of a line running roughly from London to Chester. For a generation it looked entirely possible that England would simply become a Scandinavian country. That it did not comes down to one stubborn king of Wessex, and that story, and the strange half-Norse England the Danelaw left behind, is still legible in the very street signs of the city around you.

Ragnar, the Snake Pit, and the Blood Eagle

Let me tell you the legend behind the conquest, and I want to be honest from the start that it is largely legend, wrapped around a hard kernel of real events. The story comes to us mostly from Icelandic sagas written down two or three centuries after the fact, so treat it as the Norse world's own dramatic memory of these years rather than reliable history.

The tale runs like this. Ragnar Lothbrok, whose byname means something like hairy-breeches, was a great Viking raider and king, the terror of the coasts of England and Francia. According to the saga, his career ends when he is shipwrecked raiding Northumbria and captured by its king, Ælla. Ælla, wanting a memorably grim death for so famous an enemy, has Ragnar thrown into a pit of venomous snakes. And Ragnar, dying among the serpents, is said to have laughed, and spoken a line that became famous in the North, that the little piglets would grunt when they learned how the old boar had died. The piglets were his sons. And the sons, when the news reached them, were very angry indeed.

So, the saga says, they raised the greatest army the Vikings had ever assembled, the Great Heathen Army, and sailed for England not to raid but to conquer, and above all to find King Ælla. When they took York and finally captured him, the legend claims they subjected Ælla to a ritual killing called the blood eagle, a punishment too gruesome to dwell on here, in which the victim's back was cut open in a way meant to resemble the spread wings of an eagle. It is one of the most infamous images in all of Viking lore.

Now the honest part. Did any of this happen? The real events are solid enough. There genuinely was a Great Heathen Army, it genuinely took York on the first of November, eight sixty-six, and there genuinely was a King Ælla of Northumbria who died fighting the Vikings outside these walls the following spring. But Ragnar himself may never have existed as a single real man, the snake pit is pure saga drama, and most historians now think the blood eagle is a literary invention, possibly born from a misreading of an old skaldic poem about eagles feeding on the battlefield dead, which is a normal, grisly poetic image the sagas may have taken too literally. So when you hear the blood eagle presented as historical fact, be sceptical. What is real is the fear behind the story. The people who wrote it down remembered these men as an unstoppable force of vengeance out of the sea, and they built a myth worthy of that terror. The myth is Viking. Whether the eagle ever spread its wings in this city, we will probably never know.

Half of England Under Danish Law, and the Streets That Prove It

After the sons of Ragnar broke Northumbria, the Great Army rolled on, toppling one English kingdom after another, until only one still stood, Wessex, in the south-west, and only one English king still resisted, a young, sickly, bookish man who would end up the only monarch in this country's history called the Great. Alfred.

For years it went badly for him. At one low point in eight seventy-eight, the Danes overran Wessex in a surprise winter attack and Alfred was reduced to hiding in the marshes of Somerset, a fugitive king with a handful of followers. This is the origin of that famous English legend of Alfred, in disguise, so lost in worry about his kingdom that he let a peasant woman's cakes burn on the fire and got a scolding for it. But Alfred clawed his way back, rallied an army, and defeated the Danish leader Guthrum in battle. And then he did something cleverer than winning. He made a deal.

The treaty of Alfred and Guthrum, agreed around the eight eighties, drew a line across England, running roughly up the old Roman road of Watling Street, from London north-west toward Chester. South and west of the line was English. North and east of it, the land was to be governed by Danish custom, by the law of the Danes. That is what the word means, quite literally. Danelaw, from the Old English for the law of the Danes. It was not just a military frontier, it was a legal and cultural one, an officially recognised Scandinavian England covering the whole north and east, with York as its greatest city. It would take Alfred's descendants the better part of a century to reconquer it all, and even then, the Norse imprint never washed out.

And this is the part you can see for yourself, because you spent yesterday walking through the evidence. Notice how many streets in York end in the word gate. Coppergate, Stonegate, Micklegate, Fossgate, Goodramgate. That gate has nothing to do with gateways. It is the Old Norse word gata, meaning street, dropped into the map by Danish-speaking York and never removed. Micklegate is simply the great street, from mikill, big. And here is the delicious twist that catches every visitor out. In York, the streets are called gates, but the actual gateways, the great fortified openings in the medieval city walls, are called bars. Bootham Bar, Monk Bar, Micklegate Bar. So in this city, the gates are streets and the bars are gates, and the whole beautiful muddle is a fossil of the day a Danish-speaking population lived here under Danish law. There is even a street with the marvellous name Whip-Ma-Whop-Ma-Gate, York's shortest, a linguistic accident nobody can fully explain. Every one of those signs is a small monument to the Danelaw, a thousand years old and still telling you, if you know how to read it, whose city this once was.